Russia, Ukraine, and United States: Trump-Putin deal won't impact diesel prices or produce an energy ceasefire

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Despite the diesel deal and President Donald Trump's announcement of another energy ceasefire, escalation between Russia and Ukraine remains the basecase.
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The diesel purchases, together with the Treasury license running through 7 April, will barely affect US pump prices before the 3 November midterms and will generate only limited revenue for the Russian budget.
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Trump's announcements have helped Ukraine rally its European allies, but have also increased the risk the US could withdraw intelligence support and halt arms sales.

A durable energy ceasefire remains unlikely. Kyiv's initial surprise at Trump's post, combined with Russia's silence, suggests that neither side has formally negotiated or committed to an energy truce. The Kremlin does not want such a truce before winter because cold-weather strikes are central to its strategy to force Kyiv into concessions. Trump's diesel deal, announced on 9 October, only reinforces Moscow's view that it can erode Western unity through patience and will encourage Russia to intensify strikes and other grey-zone activity over the winter.

Ukraine, for its part, would consider an aerial truce only if it were mutual. In the absence of any agreement, mutual strikes will not pause; indeed, Russia struck a power station in Ukraine's Kharkiv region several hours after the announcement. Our basecase for the rest of this year remains continued escalation without major breakthroughs on either side (see Escalation between Russia and Ukraine coming in the autumn).

Additional US pressure is unlikely to halt Ukrainian strikes on Russian refineries. Ukraine—and its European backers—see those attacks as central to its strategy to damage the Russian economy, weaken morale, and gain leverage in negotiations. Trump may still cut intelligence sharing and halt weapons sales to Ukraine, but those threats carry less weight than they did a year ago. Europe now provides more intelligence and weapons than it did at the start of Trump's presidency, and Ukraine has expanded its own drone and missile production.

Ukraine would feel the loss of US intelligence most acutely in their early warnings for ballistic strikes and for mid-range attacks on moving targets. That would likely increase damage and casualties from ballistic missile attacks and could raise battlefield losses, but it would not by itself enable a Russian breakthrough. The loss would matter less for fixed targets such as Russian refineries.

Another negative for Kyiv is that access to Starlink over Russian territory now looks even less likely. Elon Musk has publicly backed Trump's call for new Ukrainian leadership, making such coverage highly unlikely. That access would have strengthened Ukraine's campaign against Russian missile launchers.

Trump's recent steps are not a full rupture but a setback for US-Ukraine relations. The diesel deal caught Kyiv by surprise and, combined with the verbal attack on Zelensky, is widely seen as another US betrayal. Yet it does not mark a return to early 2025 when the partnership itself was put into question. The current dispute centers on fuel prices and Trump's frustration that he has few policy tools to bring them down. It likely does not reflect a broader rethink of US support for Kyiv and, notably, does not come with demands that Ukraine make concessions.

Trump's frustration with Zelensky over continued strikes on energy targets is unlikely to abate. Likely Republican losses in midterm elections—driven in part by higher costs—may exacerbate Trump's frustration. If prices do not begin to recover in late October as global supplies loosen, Trump could increase the severity of his threats to cut off intelligence sharing and other assistance.

The market effect of the ceasefire announcement and the diesel truce will be negligible. The first tranche of about 300,000 tons covers roughly half a day of US distillate consumption, not enough to significantly change prices. The impact on the Russian domestic market, fiscal position, and global supplies is also negligible; with the increased demand from the harvest season coming to an end, any surplus would have been sold to Turkey, Brazil or West Africa anyway. Redirecting cargoes to the US does not impact domestic availability or global supply.

The financial benefit for Russia will also be modest. The license will narrow the discount on Russian diesel and generate limited gains: $15-30 million in October, $70-150 million in November-December, and another $150-450 million in January-April as exports recover. Total gains would reach $1.2 billion only if the discount disappeared and exports fully rebounded. Even then, that would equal only about 0.05% of Russia's GDP. Most of the benefit will go to oil company margins, while the budget will capture only about one-quarter through profit tax. How much diesel Russia can export will largely depend on Ukrainian strikes, which have kept refinery runs well below normal (estimated at up to 50% of pre-war volumes).

President Volodymyr Zelensky will be stronger at home and in Europe. President Donald Trump's call for elections remains highly unpopular in Ukraine. Another public US betrayal in favor of Russia would probably push Ukrainians to rally around their leadership. Zelensky, weakened by corruption scandals, could benefit as domestic politics recedes and the war again takes priority. In practical terms, that shift could make it easier for him to secure additional European financial support if he is able to pass unpopular legislation through parliament.

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